This is a two-in-one soup, a mild and gentle eggplant cream yanked into high gear with a swirl of the sweeter, hotter red pepper.

eggplant and red pepper soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 25 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
THE TWO SOUPS SEPARATELY

for the eggplant soup
2 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
1 onion, chopped
1 carrot, coarsely sliced
2 tbsp chopped parsley
1 tbsp crushed coriander seeds
2 large eggplants, diced
1 tbsp risotto or short-grain rice
3¼ cups chicken or vegetable stock
salt and pepper

for the pepper soup
2 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
2 cloves garlic, chopped
1–2 fresh red chiles, seeded and chopped
2 red bell peppers, seeded and cut into strips
9oz (250g) tomatoes
1 tbsp tomato purée
1 tbsp sugar
salt and pepper
2½ cups chicken or vegetable stock
handful of fresh basil leaves

1 To make the eggplant soup, put the oil, onion, carrot, parsley, coriander, eggplant, and rice in a pan, cover, and sweat over low heat for 15 minutes. Add the stock and season with salt and pepper. Bring to a boil and simmer for 15 minutes until the carrots and rice are tender. Process in a blender.

2 To make the red pepper soup, place the olive oil, garlic, chile, and red pepper in a deep pan, and sauté until the peppers are very tender. Blanch and peel the tomatoes (see p22), then quarter, seed, and coarsely chop before adding to the pan along with the tomato purée, sugar, salt, and pepper. Cook for another 5–10 minutes until very thick. Stir in the stock and bring to a boil, then cool slightly and process to a puree in a blender.

3 Reheat both soups in separate pans, then taste and adjust seasonings. Divide the eggplant soup between 6 soup bowls and add a ladle of the pepper soup, swirling it in lightly. Sprinkle with basil and serve at once.